



BEFORE

President Lincoln had every reason to be optimistic in the wake of Robert E. Lee's surrender at Appomattox Court House. But within six days, fate cruelly intervened.

THE FIRST CONSPIRACY

Although the president had no way of knowing, **John Wilkes Booth and a band of Southern sympathizers** had made plans to **kidnap Lincoln** the previous year. Their hopes had been to hold the president as a bargaining tool in order to gain the release of [Confederate prisoners of war](#). At the time the plot was aborted, but the conspirators **remained in contact**.

PUNCTURED HOPES

The dawning [prospect of peace](#) brought great relief to Lincoln, who was intent on **promoting reconciliation with the Rebel states**. Yet the very news that cheered the president only **reignited the anger of his enemies**. A speech in which Lincoln lent his support to the cause of Black enfranchisement unwittingly **sealed his fate**. Booth was now determined to **silence him forever**.

Lincoln was in an upbeat mood on the morning of Good Friday, April 14, 1865; a political colleague remarked that he had never seen the president looking so happy. Although he was very aware of the challenges that lay ahead, the knowledge that the war was almost over gave him good reason to celebrate. Yet he was not free of personal anxieties.

A portentous dream

Just three days before, Lincoln had described to his wife and friends a dream in which he had wandered through the rooms of a deserted White House only to find a body laid out in state. When he asked an attendant who it was that had died, he was told it was the president, killed by an assassin. "I slept no more that night," Lincoln told his audience, "and although it was only a dream, I have been strangely annoyed by it ever since." Lincoln had good reason to be disturbed. From the beginning of his presidency, he had received hate mail, some of which contained threats on his life. Now lurked John Wilkes Booth. The 26-year-old, a member of a celebrated American acting dynasty, was one of the nation's leading players and a familiar face around Washington, D.C., where he often performed. A passionate supporter of the Confederate cause, the Maryland-born actor was eager to leave his mark on history through some great,